

What else to watch: *The Kid* (1921) ■ *Rome, Open City* (1945) ■ *Shoeshine* (1946) ■ *Force of Evil* (1948) ■ *Pather Panchali* (1955, pp.132–33) ■ *Kes* (1969, p.336) ■ *Slumdog Millionaire* (2008, pp.318–19) ■ *The Kid with a Bike* (2011, p.343)

of friends, they scour the local Porta Portese market, which is infamous for selling parts of broken bicycles, until finally, through a mix of determination and luck, Antonio spots the thief and pursues him into a brothel.

The thief's family and friends furiously protest the culprit's innocence, and a policeman admits there is nothing that can be done

without proof.

In desperation, Antonio himself steals a bike, but is quickly caught.

Only the kindness of its owner, after catching sight of the distressed Bruno, saves Antonio from prison. The movie closes with one of the most heart-rending

sequences in cinema, as the little boy holds hands with his humiliated father.

A universal story

The brutally simple story of *The Bicycle Thief* recounts one man's day of misfortune—one of countless similar days occurring around the world. Yet the realism of its narrow focus has a message that is universal—for those struggling to make a livelihood in an unfair world, a minor crime, such as the theft of a bicycle, assumes the scale of a great tragedy. For some critics, it is not a political movie, because, like Chaplin's *City Lights* (pp.38–41), it offers no solutions—just the transformation of a victim into a tragic hero. For others, this is what makes it a true socialist movie, because it depicts the devastating consequences of leaving people to sink or swim alone. Even before Antonio's bicycle has been stolen, a beggar foreshadows his later, »

For Antonio, his bicycle means he is a part of the world of work, and a source of pride for his son.

